A PRACTITIONER'S BRIEFING

SurveyCTO

Designing, Registering, and Deploying High-Quality Digital Field Data Collection

Covering: sign-up & registration • account types & limits • XLSForm style guide • field workflow • security

Sources: DIME Analytics SurveyCTO Style Guide · SurveyCTO Users' Guide for Field Staff · surveycto.com

OVERVIEW

What We'll Cover

01

What Is SurveyCTO?

The platform, ODK foundation, and XLSForm workflow

02

Registration & Sign-Up

Step-by-step account creation, trial and sandbox options

03

Account Types & Limits

Trial, Community, Basic, Pro, Advanced, Enterprise

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Designing High-Quality XLSForms

DIME Analytics style-guide best practices

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The Field Data Collection Workflow

From blank form to submitted, finalized dataset

06

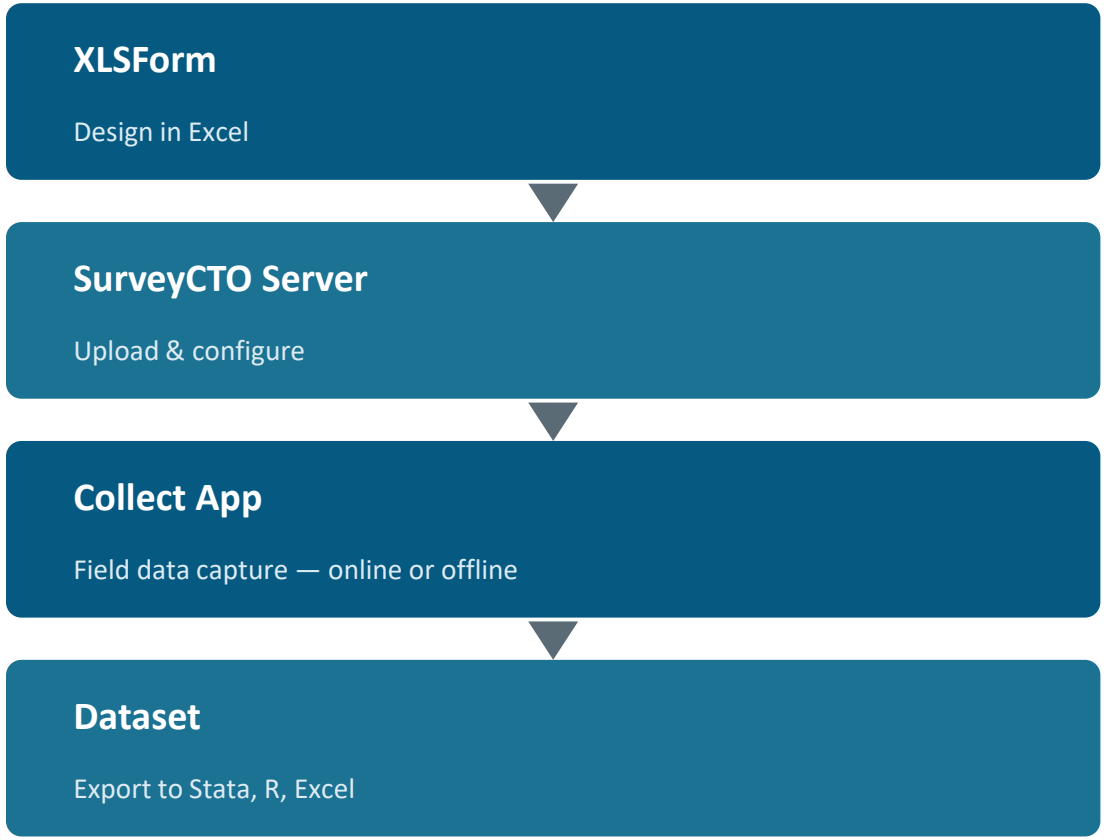
Security, Data Quality & Key Takeaways

Encryption, compliance, and closing recommendations

What Is SurveyCTO?

A professional platform for offline-capable mobile data collection, built on the open-source **ODK (Open Data Kit)** framework.

- Questionnaires are designed as XLSForms — Excel files that are simply uploaded to the server
- Works fully offline in the field, syncing data when a connection is available
- Trusted by DIME/World Bank, universities, NGOs and survey firms worldwide
- Supports complex skip logic, case management, and panel/longitudinal workflows



Why Teams Choose SurveyCTO



Advanced Offline Mode

Collect complete surveys anywhere, without a live connection



Enterprise-Grade Security

2048-bit encryption, SOC 2, GDPR & HIPAA compliance



Case Management

Track and follow up entities across longitudinal studies



Real-Time Data Quality

Automated statistical checks and live monitoring dashboards



Complex Logic & Workflows

Branching, preloaded data, and automated case assignment



Open Integrations

APIs, plug-ins, Zapier, Power BI, Salesforce and more

Registration & Sign-Up Process

1

Visit surveycto.com/plans

Compare Trial, Community, and paid subscription options

2

Choose your entry point

15-day free trial (no credit card) or free Community sandbox

3

Create your server & admin account

Pick a unique server name — yourteam.surveycto.com

4

Verify your email & set credentials

Confirm the account and set a secure password

5

Invite your team

Add unlimited users and assign roles — available on every plan

6

Install SurveyCTO Collect

Download the mobile app (Android/iOS) on every field device

Two Free Ways to Start

15-Day Free Trial

No credit card required

- All SurveyCTO features unlocked, incl. 24×7 expert support
- Limited to 10 forms · 200 submissions/month · 200MB storage
- Upgrade to a paid plan anytime without losing data

Community Subscription

Free, ongoing sandbox

- For evaluating, testing new forms, or training new staff
- Same limits as trial: 10 forms · 200 submissions/mo · 200MB
- Available indefinitely after the trial period ends

Account Types at a Glance

Plan	Price / mo*	Best For	Forms	Submissions/mo	Storage
Trial	Free (15 days)	Evaluating the platform	10	200	200 MB
Community	Free, ongoing	Testing & staff training	10	200	200 MB
Basic	$225	One-time or simple ongoing collection	100	5,000	10 GB
Pro	$315	Ongoing workflows, standard compliance	500	10,000	25 GB
Advanced	$630	Advanced, automated workflows	Unlimited	Unlimited	Unlimited
Enterprise	Custom	Org-wide / large-scale projects	Custom	Custom	Custom

** Annual-subscription rate shown; monthly billing is ~11% higher. All paid plans include unlimited users & devices, 24×7 expert support, and public-private key encryption.*

What Scales as You Upgrade

Basic

- Standard GDPR DPA
- SOC 2 certified
- Basic offline case mgmt.
- 100,000 AI tokens*

Pro

- Server location selection
- All plug-ins + limited API
- Annual SOC 2 report
- 250,000 AI tokens*

Advanced

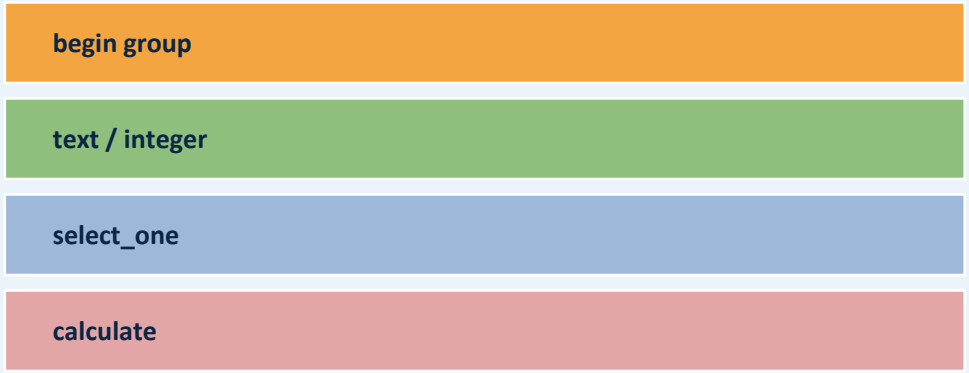
- Custom GDPR DPA
- Full APIs & plug-ins
- Advanced offline case mgmt.
- 500,000 AI tokens*

**AI token allowance supports built-in AI transcription and translation tools.*

Readable Forms Start with Structure

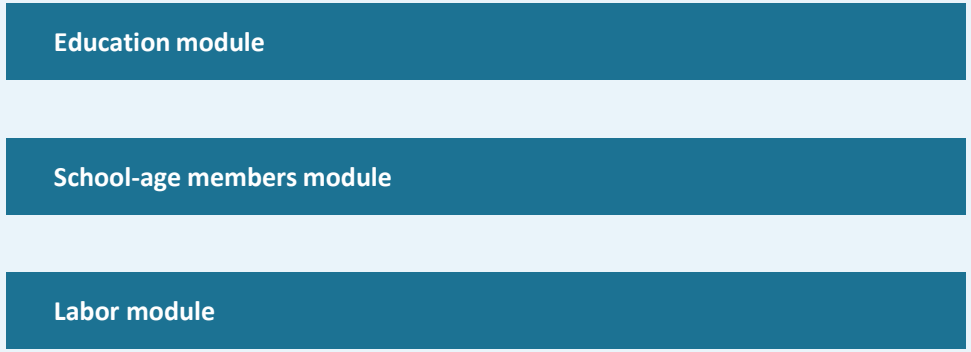
Color-Code Rows by Field Type

Give every question type (text, integer, select_one, calculate…) a consistent color. A coder can then scan the sheet and instantly find, say, every integer field to update a constraint — no need to read every row.



Use White Space Between Modules

Empty rows between modules don’t affect execution, but they let readers instantly see where one section (e.g. Household Roster) ends and the next (e.g. Assets) begins — critical for 100+ question instruments.



Version Control & Matching Group Names

Automate the Form Version

A form's version must be lexically greater than the one already on the server. Instead of typing it by hand, use a formula tied to the system clock in the settings sheet:

```
=TEXT(YEAR(NOW())-2000,"00") &
TEXT(MONTH(NOW()),"00") &
TEXT(DAY(NOW()),"00") & …
```

Result: teams always pick up a colleague's latest edits instead of overwriting them.

Name Both begin_ and end_ Fields

ODK only requires begin_group / begin_repeat to be named — but naming the matching end_ field too makes large, nested questionnaires far easier to debug and divide among team members.

begin group	`hhr_education`
...questions...	
end group	`hhr_education`

Matching names = the ietestform Stata command (DIME Analytics) can verify every group closes correctly.

Naming Variables & Coding Choice Lists

Variable Naming Convention

```
module_varname_add
```

- Letters (a–z), digits (0–9), and underscores only
- Lowercase only — Stata & R are case-sensitive
- Max 32 characters (Stata's hard limit); flagged by ietestform

Standardized Choice Codes

Value	Meaning
1, 2, 3…	Ordinary numeric answer options
-9	“Other”
-88	“Refuse to answer”
-99	“Do not know”

Numeric, standardized codes make relevance/constraint logic (e.g. ${occupation} = 4) reliable across the whole form — text values like “Factory Worker” must match character-for-character to work.

Speak the Respondent's Language, Keep the Data Numeric

Numeric codes are great for analysis — but confusing if read aloud. A calculate field with choice_label() lets the enumerator see the word while the dataset still stores the number.

✗ Without a Choice Label

“How much area (in hectares) is cultivated under 5?”

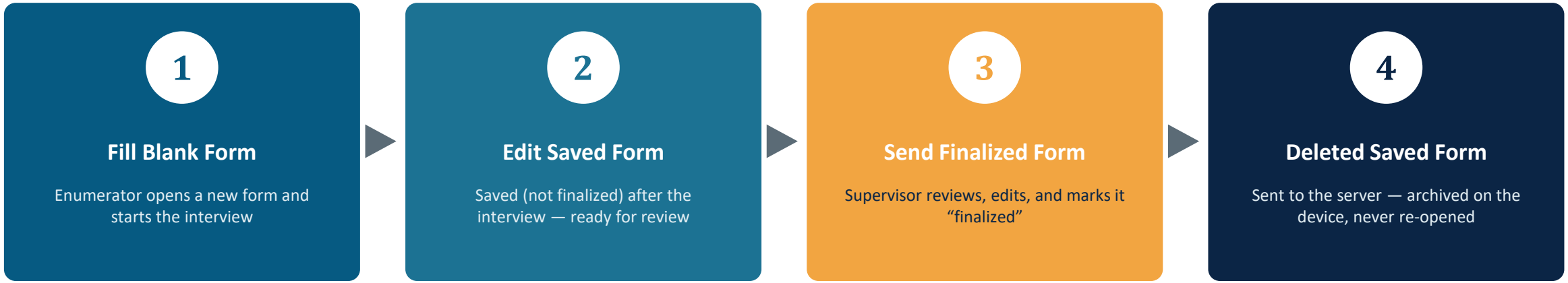
The enumerator and respondent have no idea what “5” refers to — the flow of the interview breaks down.

✓ With choice_label()

“How much area (in hectares) is cultivated under maize?”

The exported variable crop_name still stores the numeric code “5” — clean for Stata/R, clear for the interview.

The Life of a Form on a Device



Golden rule: never reopen and edit a form that has already been sent — doing so creates duplicate submissions on the server.

Field Staff: Device & Data Habits



Charge nightly

Charge devices every night; always carry a charger and a paper backup



Correct date & time

SurveyCTO logs device date/time — it feeds directly into data quality checks



Wi-Fi & data off during interviews

Saves battery and avoids forms being auto-sent before they're reviewed



Save regularly

Tap the save icon during long interviews so no answers are ever lost



Never edit a sent form

Reopening a submitted form creates duplicate records on the server



Connect only to sync

Internet is needed only to download blank forms and send finalized ones

Security, Compliance & Data Quality

1

2048-bit Encryption

Public-private key encryption on every form and submission

2

SOC 2 Type 2 Certified

Independently audited security controls; report available annually

3

GDPR & HIPAA Compliant

Standard or custom Data Processing Agreements by plan

4

SSO Support

Single sign-on via Google, Okta, and Azure AD

5

99.9% Uptime

Data redundancy and automated backups

6

Live Data Quality Checks

Real-time visualization and automated statistical review

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Build It Right, Register Wisely, Collect With Confidence

- Start with the free trial or Community sandbox before committing to a paid plan
- Match the plan (Basic → Enterprise) to your submission volume, storage, and compliance needs
- Follow the DIME Analytics style guide — color coding, white space, and clear naming save hours downstream
- Standardize choice codes and load choice labels so data stays clean and interviews stay natural
- Train field staff on the save → review → finalize → send workflow to protect data integrity

Thank you — Questions?

surveycto.com · docs.surveycto.com · DIME Analytics